

Chapter 109 - Past Life

These words made the hair on the back of Ning Fuyi's neck stand up for a moment. She didn't reply, only stared fixedly at the old man.

The old man had originally wanted to see her frightened appearance, but seeing her so shocked, he suddenly found it boring. He reached out to push aside the obstructing flowers around him and shakily stood up.

"You're quite boring, little girl. The last one was at least well-behaved and fun to tease." Emperor Fengdu walked with his hands behind his back toward the depths of the flower bushes. The dense flowers that touched his feet immediately avoided him in alarm, making his path as smooth as level ground.

"Are you talking about a woman in white robes who looks extremely beautiful?" Ning Fuyi asked from the outer edge.

"I never look at faces - I look at the souls within. Whether someone is beautiful or not, this old man cannot tell. I can only see that her obsession was too deep, and her heart was too clean and pure - she was born to suffer." Emperor Fengdu's voice grew fainter as his footsteps moved away, becoming somewhat blurred, covered by wind sounds from who knows where.

Ning Fuyi knew he was leading her in. She extended one foot, but just as she was about to touch the flower petals, she quickly stopped, withdrew her leg, and sat down cross-legged on the spot.

This old man was waiting here for no reason, clearly knowing of her entry into the underworld and wanting to see her suffer from the flowers' cutting pain. She didn't know where this malicious amusement came from.

Old people just loved these mysterious tricks. She wouldn't fall for his scheme - let's see what he could do.

Sure enough, after half an incense stick's time, the old man who had walked far away came walking back with his body, his eyes that couldn't open before now wide open, clutching his belly and gasping.

"You..." The old man pointed at her for a while, then threw his sleeve high and sat down heavily, twisting his beard. The red spider lilies under his bottom couldn't dodge in time and were silently pressed underneath.

If Su Mo were here, he would probably have been able to see these flowers screaming. Ning Fuyi's thoughts suddenly drifted to the mortal world.

"Tsk ts, those eyes, so pitiful and sorrowful." Emperor Fengdu examined her while treating his braided beard like prayer beads.

Ning Fuyi immediately erased Su Mo's appearance from her mind, lowered her eyes and said: "What exactly does senior want to tell this junior? What about future matters - please help clarify my doubts, senior."

Emperor Fengdu looked at her and smiled, saying proudly: "You're not easy to talk to, little girl. You didn't amuse this old man just now, so why should I tell you?"

Ning Fuyi raised her eyes. Her pupils reflected the crimson color of the red spider lilies as she met the gaze of Emperor Fengdu's eyes that carried the weight of heavy years.

She didn't get angry, but said: "Since senior watches ghosts all day and hasn't seen enough, and so wants to see people in agonizing pain, then please watch."

After saying this, she suddenly stood up and stepped into the red spider lily grove. Countless sensations of blades cutting through skin quickly occupied her consciousness. For a moment, Ning Fuyi's mind went completely blank, but she stood upright, neither pulling out nor falling down.

Just as she was about to step in with her other leg, a gust of wind suddenly wrapped around her waist, pulling her entire body out of the flower grove and back onto the field ridge.

Only then did Ning Fuyi's knees give way, staggering and kneeling on the ground.

Snow-white whiskers floated toward her, and the old man muttered as he crouched down, his plump body quite helpless: "This old man just wanted you to beg for mercy. How are you just like that girl - looking so delicate and tender, yet possessing such iron bones?"

"What, do you look down on girls?" Ning Fuyi's nose tip was beaded with sweat from pain as she looked at him coldly.

"Not at all." The old man glanced at her leg, saw that not much blood was flowing, and sat back down. "Fine, since you've bled, this old man doesn't want to hide anything either."

"All things in the world have their way, but time is the source of all ways. Since heaven and earth were first created, it took countless eons to nurture life, and countless more eons to give birth to the six realms¹. After the six realms were chaotic for a long time, only then did the Heavenly Dao² come into being. Therefore, all living beings have variables, but only time flows as usual, unchanging through eternity."

When the old man sat up straight, that playful attitude disappeared, and only then did he somewhat resemble the legendary Emperor Fengdu.

"So, were you reborn?" Ning Fuyi keenly grasped the word "time" and asked tentatively.

Emperor Fengdu saw through her probing thoughts, grinned and laughed, shaking his head: "You really are quite guarded, only asking about me and not about us, afraid that others might know about your rebirth."

"There are many bad people - one must be cautious." Ning Fuyi replied. Her body suddenly trembled a little. "So you also know about my rebirth?"

"Although that reincarnation array was effective, it couldn't completely erase all traces of those thousand years experienced. There were inevitably some remnants - like yours and my memories, and like the red spider lily roots that never disappear after the flowers are cut." Emperor Fengdu glanced toward the depths of the flower sea.

"Those who retained memories might be like you - those whose suffering hasn't subsided after great tribulation, or those with obsessions too deep to eliminate, or like this old man - those with exceptional power." Emperor Fengdu said.

This old man still didn't forget to boast about himself. Amid her shock, Ning Fuyi thought vaguely.

"However, the remaining traces are very few, and most reborn people keep it secret, so you didn't know. But..." The old man's expression became more serious.

"Time is the foundation of all things, so those who disturb time, even if what they do is to save the world, are still enemies of the Heavenly Dao. They must suffer chaos punishment - having all immortal power and immortal bones stripped away, thrown into chaos, subjected to thunder punishment daily, until a hundred years pass before they can be released."

"However, even after serving the sentence, the sin is not eliminated. In future reincarnations, they must have miserable fates, suffering all the hardships of the mortal world, unable to escape life after life."

Ning Fuyi listened somewhat confused, but still couldn't help clenching her hands, her heart aching with his words.

"So my mother..."

"No, it wasn't your mother who committed the sin." Emperor Fengdu said.

"Then was it me?" Ning Fuyi frowned. After all, she was the one who set up the reincarnation array in her previous life.

Unexpectedly, Emperor Fengdu shook his head and sighed: "Not you either. You weren't the one who set up the array."

Emperor Fengdu's words each seemed to unravel mysteries, but each also made the tangle in Ning Fuyi's heart even more confused. She suddenly had a headache and supported her temple with her index finger, a name suddenly flashing through her mind.

"Chu Qingqiu?" She quickly raised her head. "But..."

"Yes, it was her." Emperor Fengdu said.

Ning Fuyi stood there stunned. She felt her mind had never been so inadequate as today. The person who invented the reincarnation array was Ning Changfeng, the person who set up the array was clearly herself, and she died under Chu Qingqiu's sword - wasn't this the truth?

How could it become Chu Qingqiu?

Emperor Fengdu let her digest this for a while before continuing: "This matter is too complex, involving many things. This old man doesn't understand everything either. I only chatted with that girl a thousand years later and learned a thing or two."

Ning Fuyi racked her brains, trying to find the source of this tangle: "I once saw in my mother's manuscript the reincarnation array she drew. Although it was roughly the same, it lacked the most crucial array center."

"Could it be that what my mother drew was only a prototype, not the final reincarnation array, and the person who ultimately drew the complete reincarnation array was Chu Qingqiu?"

As these words left her mouth, Ning Fuyi seemed to immediately understand. She could no longer sit still and couldn't help standing up, the pain in her leg long forgotten.

"So in my previous life, when I was being hunted by the immortal gates and she disappeared for so long, she wasn't watching coldly from the sidelines, but because she had drawn the complete reincarnation array and was imprisoned in chaos by the Heavenly Dao, enduring thunder punishment!"

Ning Fuyi was somewhat breathless. Her lips parted slightly, indescribable emotions crashed through her mind, making her eyes slightly red.

It was Chu Qingqiu who put the array into her prayer bead, allowing her to discover it, and after her death, entered the underworld to pull her out of the flower sea that trapped her soul.

Emperor Fengdu saw her standing there for a long time, perhaps having figured out some things, and only then looked at the crimson sky and said: "This old man remembers that the day I saw that girl, she was covered in blood, tearing through the barrier between the netherworld and the outside world with her bare hands, stumbling and rushing onto this Naihe Bridge³, looking for a soul named Ning Fuyi."

"Never before had a living person come to the underworld, attracting countless ghost officials to pressure her, but they were all beaten by her until they had no power to fight back. As a last resort, they had to invite me, who had been in seclusion for a long time."

"After hearing her description, I brought her to find you, who had already become a red spider lily. The netherworld is the place of rebirth for the other five realms. Although it's said to be within the six realms, it has actually long transcended them. So these people who have become red spider lilies, even if time were reversed a hundred times, could never become human again."

"You should have completely disappeared from this world, unless someone was willing to endure bone-cutting pain, find your soul from these countless flower groves, and bring you out of the underworld - only then could this rule be broken."

"That day she had almost become a blood person. I had never seen such deep obsession. The flower groves she walked through were frighteningly brilliant. Even I couldn't help but feel pity." Emperor Fengdu's eyes were distant as he reminisced.

The wound on Ning Fuyi's right foot began to hurt again, making her whole body tremble with pain.

"Chu Qingqiu brought back my soul, then activated the array to make time flow backward." The more her right leg hurt, the clearer Ning Fuyi's thoughts became, and her tone became more normal.

Emperor Fengdu nodded and said "correct": "Although the netherworld is isolated from the world, I remember that by then all six realms were in chaos, the underworld was overcrowded and couldn't reincarnate. Countless demons and monsters roamed the world, immortal gates withered and were almost extinct, the mortal world was plagued with natural disasters and man-made calamities - the end had come."

The world-destroyer. It really was her. Ning Fuyi's legs felt somewhat weak.

But why did she have no memory of these things Emperor Fengdu spoke of? The memories in her mind were too fragmented and chaotic. Originally she thought it was due to time.

It seemed now that this wasn't the case.

"That girl had the common people at heart and was unwilling to let the world be destroyed all at once, and also unwilling to let you disappear just like that. That's why she used her life to drive the reincarnation array, making time flow backward to reverse the absurdity of the previous life."

"So this old man didn't stop her either." Emperor Fengdu said. Having finally said everything in his heart, he now relaxed, leaning back and lying in the flower grove, quite comfortable.

"Now what should be said has been said. Anything more is your business. This old man only manages life and death, not the common people." Emperor Fengdu swayed his feet and laughed. "Go back."

"Oh right." Emperor Fengdu suddenly remembered something, rummaging through his oceanic beard with his fingertips and pulling out a wrinkled, very old silk booklet, throwing it to Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi was still in a daze, catching the book by bodily memory. It felt light as cloud fluff, with several flowing ancient characters written in unknown ink.

"This book is called 'Divine Demon Manual'⁴. I copied it down when I followed the gods in cultivation back in the day. I think it will be useful to you - take it and study it." He sighed, and then snoring sounds began echoing through the flower sea.

Ning Fuyi opened the booklet and looked. Inside were all ancient characters, extremely obscure and difficult to understand.

She was about to speak and ask more, but the crimson sky overhead was suddenly torn open with a crack, and the wailing sounds of fierce ghosts immediately filled her mind.

Then a white light flashed, and she had already fallen under the blazing sun, with continuous snow under her feet and scattered towns in the distance. The aroma of wine drifted from deep alleys, and the sound of firecrackers entered her ears.

This year was finally ending. No matter how the year was spent, when New Year arrived, it had to be celebrated with great fanfare.

Ning Fuyi looked down at her still bleeding foot. She raised her hand, and pink mist slowly descended. Although the bleeding stopped, the scar would remain there forever.

Her reddened phoenix eyes curved downward. She raised her head to bathe in the clear, cold sunlight, enjoying this moment of tranquility.

She was suddenly looking forward to next spring when the heavy snow melted, wondering what expression would hang on Chu Qingqiu's cold and proud face when she looked at her.

Footnotes:

¹ **Six Realms (六界)** - In Chinese mythology and cultivation fiction, refers to the six domains of existence: Heaven, Asura, Human, Animal, Hungry Ghost, and Hell realms

² **Heavenly Dao (天道)** - The Way of Heaven, representing the natural order and laws that govern the universe in Chinese philosophy and cultivation fiction

³ **Naihe Bridge (奈何桥)** - The "Bridge of Helplessness" in Chinese mythology that souls must cross in the underworld

⁴ **Divine Demon Manual (神魔诀)** - A cultivation manual containing techniques that work with both divine and demonic powers